

and automatically switches on is a good option to have. As is a pop-up flash that can be used for still pictures. Image stabilisation is also important, and the zoom capabilities can be helpful when you want to take close-up shots.

If you're planning to use your camcorder on vacations and in the outdoors, it should be compact and lightweight, have long battery life, be able to take good still pictures, and should have a good viewfinder. The functionality of the viewfinder can be replaced with that of an LCD screen, but LCDs typically are hard to see in sunlight. You should also consider a wind screen for the microphone and the audio zoom feature that enables you to "zoom" into the audio in the direction in which the camcorder is focused or zoomed in. If you decide to do away with the tripod, be sure to check out for good image stabilisation capabilities. Zoom features will also be needed if you want to take long-range shots.

For sports enthusiasts, your camcorder should support fast shutter speeds, manual control, image stabilisation, and 10x or higher optical zoom. You should also consider a tripod if your shots are going to be over long periods of time.

Parents who wish to capture their kids' every moment through school plays, elocutions and such should look for camcorders that give good low-light performance, good audio or external audio support, 10x or higher optical zoom, and a tripod.

If you are a budding film maker, you will want a camcorder that gives you a great deal of manual control, support for external audio and lighting, and widescreen and cinematic effects. You may also need features like in-camera editing and deletion of scenes, and a whole kit of accessories ranging from the basic tripod to professional audio equipment so you can get that perfect audio stream with your video.